6.S974 Games, Learning, and Security
HW2

Erich Trieschman

November 1, 2026

Problem 1 (Cybersecurity with Incomplete Information)

(a) **Pure strategies.** A strategy specifies a choice for each type.

- Attacker ($\theta_1 = 4, \theta_1 = 8$): $\{(A, A), (A, N), (N, A), (N, N)\}$
- Company: ($\theta_2 = 1, \theta_2 = 3$): $\{(P, P), (P, U), (U, P), (U, U)\}$

A strategy profile is a tuple of one pure strategy per player. In this case each player has four pure strategies, so there are $4 \times 4 = 16$ strategy profiles.

(b) **Prior and beliefs.** Types are equally likely to occur and independent so

$$p(\theta_1, \theta_2) = \tfrac{1}{2} \times \tfrac{1}{2} = \tfrac{1}{4}, \qquad \forall\, \theta_1,\ \forall\, \theta_2$$

Beliefs are conditional on the attacker or the company's types

$$\mu_1(\theta_2 = 1 \mid \theta_1 = 4) = \frac{p(4,1)}{p(4,1) + p(4,3)} = \frac{\frac{1}{4}}{\frac{1}{4} + \frac{1}{4}} = \tfrac{1}{2}$$

Because the prior is uniform over (θ_1, θ_2), this belief holds for every player's type for every other player's type so

$$\mu_1(\theta_2 \mid \theta_1) = \mu_2(\theta_1 \mid \theta_2) = \tfrac{1}{2}$$

(c) **Pure strategy best response.** Expected payoff when company plays P is $E_{A\sim\alpha}[u_2(P, A)] = -\alpha\theta_2 - (1-\alpha)\theta_2 = -\theta_2$ and when company plays U is $E_{A\sim\alpha}[u_2(U, A)] = -4\alpha$, so

$$BR_2(\alpha) = \begin{cases} P & \theta_2 < 4\alpha \\ \{P, U\} & \theta_2 = 4\alpha \\ U & \text{else} \end{cases} \implies \begin{cases} (P,P) & \alpha \geq \frac{3}{4} \\ (P,U) & \frac{1}{4} \leq \alpha \leq \frac{3}{4} \\ (U,P) & \text{never} \\ (U,U) & \alpha \leq \frac{1}{4} \end{cases}$$

And for the attacker we get $E_{P\sim\pi}[u_1(P, A)] = -\pi + (1-\pi)(\theta_1 - 1) = (1-\pi)\theta_1 - 1$ and $E_{P\sim\pi}[u_1(P, N)] = 0$

$$BR_1(\pi) = \begin{cases} A & \pi < 1 - \frac{1}{\theta_1} \\ \{A, N\} & \pi = 1 - \frac{1}{\theta_1} \\ N & \text{else} \end{cases} \implies \begin{cases} (A,A) & \pi \leq \frac{3}{4} \\ (A,N) & \text{never} \\ (N,A) & \frac{3}{4} \leq \pi \leq \frac{7}{8} \\ (N,N) & \pi \geq \frac{7}{8} \end{cases}$$

(d) **Does a pure strategy Bayes Nash Equilibrium exist?**

- Begin with attacker pure strategy (A, A): $\sigma_1(A \mid \theta_1 = 4) = 1 = \sigma_1(A \mid \theta_1 = 8)$ so $\alpha = 1$. From part (c) $BR_2(1) = (P, P)$. By the same logic company pure strategy (P, P) yields $\pi = 1$ $BR_1(1) = (N, N)$. Repeating, attacker pure strategy (N, N) yields $\alpha = 0$ and $BR_2(0) = (U, U)$. Company pure strategy (U, U) yields $\pi = 0$ and $BR_1(0) = (A, A)$, returning us to the start of the cycle. So there's no pure strategy Bayes Nash Equilibrium with any combination of $((A, A), (N, N))$ and $((P, P), (U, U))$
- Take attacker pure strategy (A, N) yielding $\alpha = \frac{1}{2}$ and $BR_2(\frac{1}{2}) = (P, U)$. The company's best response yields $\pi = \frac{1}{2}$ and $BR_1(\frac{1}{2}) = (A, A)$, returning us to the first cycle.
- Take attacker strategy (N, A) yielding $\alpha = \frac{1}{2}$. This produces the same $BR_2(\frac{1}{2}) = (P, U)$ above returning us to the first cycle.

Hence by process of elimination, there is no pure strategy Bayes Nash Equilibrium.

(e) **Bayesian Nash Equilibrium in behavioral strategies.**

Necessary condition $\pi = \frac{3}{4}$ By contradiction suppose $\pi \neq \frac{3}{4}$ in equilibrium. Recall that a mixed action is a best response only if every action in its support is a pure best response by theorem.

Case 1 $(\pi > 3/4)$**.** For any $\pi > 3/4$ attacker type $\theta_1 = 4$ has only a pure best response N (because mixed best response requires pure best response in its support) and $\sigma_1(A \mid \theta_1 = 4) = 0$. So $\alpha = \sigma_1(A \mid \theta_1 = 8)/2$, which implies $\alpha \leq 1/2$.

For any $\alpha \leq 1/2$ the company type $\theta_2 = 3$ has only a pure best response U and $\sigma_2(P \mid \theta_2 = 3) = 0$. So $\pi = \sigma_2(P \mid \theta_2 = 1)/2$, which implies $\pi \leq 1/2$, a contradiction to $\pi > 3/4$.

Case 2 $(\pi < 3/4)$ For any $\pi < 3/4$ the attacker has only a pure best response (A, A) and $\alpha = 1$. For $\alpha = 1$ the company has only a pure best response (P, P) and $\pi = 1$, contradicting $\pi < 3/4$.

Therefore if there exists a Bayesian Nash Equilibrium a necessary condition would be $\pi = 3/4$.

Mixed strategy. The probability of protecting $\pi = 3/4$ gives $\sigma_2(P \mid 1) + \sigma_2(P \mid 3) = 3/2$, which implies at least one company type randomizes, since pure company strategies give $\sigma_2(P \mid 1) + \sigma_2(P \mid 3) \in \{0, 1, 2\}$.

Moreover, for $\pi = 3/4$ the best response of attacker type $\theta_1 = 8$ is A, implying a probability of attack $\alpha \geq 1/2$.

For the company to have a mixed strategy and $\alpha \geq 1/2$, it must be that $\alpha = 3/4$ so that the mixed strategy best response can have a support greater than 1: the company type $\theta_1 = 3$ is indifferent at $\alpha = 3/4$ and type $\theta_1 = 1$ is not.

This support tells us that company type $\theta_2 = 1$ has a pure strategy best response of P and $\sigma_2(P \mid 1) = 1$. Plugging this into our equation for π above we get $\sigma_2(P \mid 3) = 1/2$.

Note that $\sigma_1(A \mid 8) = 1$ follows directly from attacker type $\theta_1 = 8$'s best response of A. Solving $\alpha = 3/4 = (1 + \sigma_1(A \mid 4))/2$ gives $\sigma_1(A \mid 4) = 1/2$.

Therefore if there is a mixed strategy Bayesian Nash Equilibrium it must be that

$$\sigma_2(P \mid 3) = 1/2 = \sigma_1(A \mid 4), \quad \sigma_2(P \mid 1) = 1 = \sigma_1(A \mid 8).$$

Suffice to validate.

Validation. From definition, the strategy profile is a Bayes Nash Equilibrium if for every player and every type the strategy is a best response. At the candidate profile $\pi = 3/4$ and $\alpha = 3/4$.

$$\begin{aligned}
\text{supp}(\sigma_1(\cdot \mid \theta_1 = 4)) = \{A, N\} &\subseteq BR_1(\tfrac{3}{4} \mid \theta_1 = 4) = \{A, N\} \\
\text{supp}(\sigma_1(\cdot \mid \theta_1 = 8)) = \{A\} &\subseteq BR_1(\tfrac{3}{4} \mid \theta_1 = 8) = \{A\} \\
\text{supp}(\sigma_2(\cdot \mid \theta_2 = 1)) = \{P\} &\subseteq BR_2(\tfrac{3}{4} \mid \theta_2 = 1) = \{P\} \\
\text{supp}(\sigma_2(\cdot \mid \theta_2 = 3)) = \{P, U\} &\subseteq BR_2(\tfrac{3}{4} \mid \theta_2 = 3) = \{P, U\}
\end{aligned}$$

Each condition above was necessary for equilibrium, so it is the unique BNE.

Problem 2 (Signaling through Safety Certification)

(a) **Game tree.**

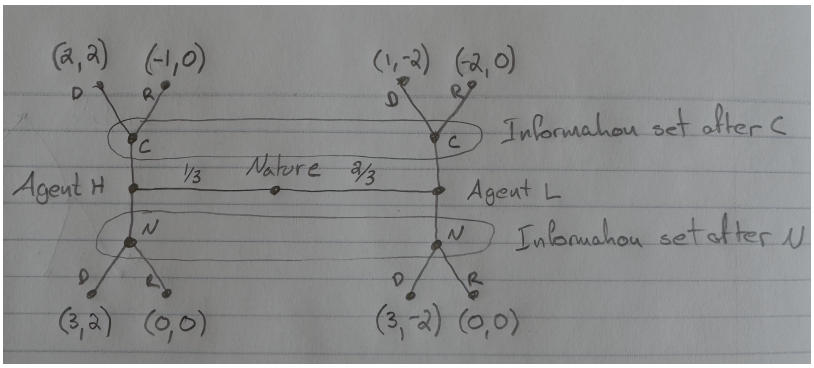


Figure 1: Problem 2 Part (a) game tree

(b) **Does a separating PBE exist?** A separating PBE exists if a strategy profile (s^*, μ^*) satisfies

1. *Sequential rationality.* At every information set I each player's continuation strategy $s_i^*\big|_I$ maximizes expected payoff given beliefs $\mu_i^*(\cdot \mid I)$ and the other players' continuation strategies $s_{-i}^*\big|_I$.
2. *Belief consistency.* At information sets I reached with positive probability, beliefs $\mu_i^*(\cdot \mid I)$ are obtained from the prior and equilibrium strategies s^* using Bayes' rule.
3. *Separating.* Each provider type chooses a different signal.

Candidate provider strategy profiles are $s_1(H, L) \in \{(C, N), (N, C)\}$.

Profile (C, N)**.** Under belief consistency the operator's beliefs $\mu_2(\cdot \mid m_1)$ are

$$\mu_2(H \mid C) = \frac{P(C \mid H)P(H)}{P(C \mid H)P(H) + P(C \mid L)P(L)} = \frac{1 * 1/3}{1 * 1/3 + 0} = 1, \qquad \mu_2(L \mid C) = 0,$$
$$\mu_2(H \mid N) = 0, \qquad \mu_2(L \mid N) = 1.$$

Under sequential rationality, the operator's strategy is $s_2(C) = D$ and $s_2(N) = R$.

In equilibrium, the provider should not have an incentive to deviate. When $\theta_1 = H$, selecting N decreases provider payoff from $2 \to 0$. When $\theta_1 = L$, selecting C increases provider payoff from $0 \to 1$. So (C, N) is not a separating PBE.

Profile (N, C)**.** Operator beliefs are

$$\mu_2(H \mid C) = 0, \qquad \mu_2(L \mid C) = 1, \qquad \mu_2(H \mid N) = 1, \qquad \mu_2(L \mid N) = 0.$$

The operator's strategy is $s_2(C) = R$ and $s_2(N) = D$. When $\theta_1 = H$, selecting C decreases provider payoff from $3 \to -1$. When $\theta_1 = L$, selecting N increases provider payoff from $-2 \to 3$. So (N, C) is not a separating PBE.

Therefore, there does not exist a separating PBE.

(c) **Pooling PBE.** Now consider a pooling PBE where $s_1(H) = s_1(L) = N$.

The operator's beliefs are

$$\mu_2(H \mid N) = \frac{P(N \mid H)P(H)}{P(N \mid H)P(H) + P(N \mid L)P(L)} = \frac{1 * 1/3}{1 * 1/3 + 1 * 2/3} = 1/3, \quad \mu_2(L \mid N) = 2/3.$$

The operator's strategy is based on expected payoffs

$$E_{\theta_1}[u_2(N, R \mid \theta_1)] = 0, \qquad E_{\theta_1}[u_2(N, D \mid \theta_1)] = 1/3 * 2 + 2/3 * (-2) = -2/3$$

and its strategy is $s_2(N) = R$.

Bayes rule cannot determine $\mu_2(\cdot \mid C)$. Let $\mu_2 := \mu_2(H \mid C)$ and ask what beliefs can discourage both provider types from deviating from N:

$$E_{\theta_1}[u_2(C, R \mid \theta_1)] = 0, \qquad E_{\theta_1}[u_2(C, D \mid \theta_1)] = \mu_2 * 2 + (1 - \mu_2) * (-2) = 4\mu_2 - 2.$$

Comparing the two expected payoffs we see for any $\mu_2 \leq 1/2$ the operator's best response would be $s_2(C) = R$. Choose $\mu_2 = 0$ so $s_2(N) = s_2(C) = R$ and examine the provider's best response.

When $\theta_1 = H$, selecting C decreases payoffs from $0 \to -1$ and when $\theta_1 = L$, selecting C decreases payoff from $0 \to -2$.

Therefore the profile $s^* = (s_1(H) = s_1(L) = N, s_2(C) = s_2(N) = R)$, together with beliefs $\mu_2(H \mid N) = 1/3$ (from Bayes' rule) and $\mu_2(H \mid C) = 0$ (chosen), is a pooling PBE.

(d) **Behavioral strategy for a semi-separating equilibrium.**

Suppose $\sigma_1(C \mid H) = 1,\ \sigma_1(C \mid L) = p \in (0, 1)$.

Operator beliefs.

$$\mu_2(H \mid C) = \frac{\sigma_1(C \mid H)P(H)}{\sigma_1(C \mid H)P(H) + pP(L)} = \frac{1 * 1/3}{1 * 1/3 + 2p/3} = \frac{1}{1 + 2p}, \qquad \mu_2(L \mid C) = \frac{2p}{1 + 2p}$$
$$\mu_2(H \mid N) = 0, \qquad \mu_2(L \mid N) = 1.$$

$\sigma_2(\cdot \mid \mathbf{N})$. When the provider plays N the operator has a pure best response of $s_2(N) = R$ since

$$E_{\theta_1}[u_2(N, D \mid \theta_1)] = 0 * 2 + 1 * (-2) < 0 = E_{\theta_1}[u_2(N, R \mid \theta_1)]$$

So $\sigma_2(R \mid N) = 1 = 1 - \sigma_2(D \mid N)$.

$\sigma_1(\cdot \mid \mathbf{L})$. When the provider plays C, the operator can play a mixed strategy only if both pure strategies are in its best response. This occurs when

$$\begin{aligned} E_{\theta_1 \sim \mu_2}[u_2(C, D \mid \theta_1)] &= 0 = E_{\theta_1 \sim \mu_2}[u_2(C, R \mid \theta_1)] \\ 2 * \mu_2(H \mid C) + -2 * \mu_2(L \mid C) &= 0 \\ 2/(1 + 2p) - 4p/(1 + 2p) &= 0 \\ p &= 1/2 \end{aligned}$$

So $\sigma_1(C \mid L) = 1/2 = \sigma_1(N \mid L)$.

$\sigma_2(\cdot \mid \mathbf{C})$. Let $\sigma_2(D \mid C) = q$ and recall $\sigma_2(R \mid N) = 1$. For a behavioral strategy equilibrium we must find q such that the provider of type $\theta_1 = L$ is indifferent between actions C and N:

$$\begin{aligned} E_{\sigma_2}[u_1(C, \sigma_2 \mid L)] &= E_{\sigma_2}[u_1(N, \sigma_2 \mid L)] \\ q * 1 + (1-q)(-2) &= 0 = u_1(N, R \mid L) \\ q &= 2/3 \end{aligned}$$

So $\sigma_2(D \mid C) = 2/3 = 1 - \sigma_2(R \mid C)$.

$\sigma_1(\cdot \mid \mathbf{H})$ It suffices to show $\sigma_1(C \mid H) = 1 = 1 - \sigma_1(N \mid H)$ is a best response:

$$E_{\sigma_2}[u_1(C, \sigma_2 \mid H)] = 2/3 * 2 + 1/3(-1) = 1 \geq 0 = E_{\sigma_2}[u_1(N, \sigma_2 \mid H)]$$

So $s_1(H) = C$ is a pure strategy best response confirming the check.

Equilibrium. Therefore the following strategy profile

$$\begin{aligned} &\sigma_1(C \mid H) = 1, \quad \sigma_1(N \mid H) = 0, \quad \sigma_1(C \mid L) = 1/2, \quad \sigma_1(N \mid L) = 1/2. \\ &\sigma_2(D \mid C) = 2/3, \quad \sigma_2(R \mid C) = 1/3, \quad \sigma_2(D \mid N) = 0, \quad \sigma_2(R \mid N) = 1. \end{aligned}$$

with beliefs

$$\begin{aligned} \mu_2(H \mid C) &= 1/2, & \mu_2(L \mid C) &= 1/2 \\ \mu_2(H \mid N) &= 0, & \mu_2(L \mid N) &= 1. \end{aligned}$$

is a PBE in behavioral strategies.

Probability of unreliable and deployed.

$$\begin{aligned} P(D, L) &= P(D \mid L)P(L) \\ &= \big[P(D \mid L, C)P(C \mid L) + P(D \mid L, N)P(N \mid L)\big]P(L) && \text{(law of total probability)} \\ &= \big[\sigma_2(D \mid C)\sigma_1(C \mid L) + \sigma_2(D \mid N)\sigma_1(N \mid L)\big]P(L) && \text{(plugging in strategy profiles)} \\ &= \big[\tfrac{2}{3} \cdot \tfrac{1}{2} + 0 \cdot \tfrac{1}{2}\big]\tfrac{2}{3} \\ &= \tfrac{2}{9} \end{aligned}$$

Problem 3 (Traffic routing problem)

(a) **Wardrop equilibrium.** For signal s all paths that carry positive flow must have same expected latency:

$$x^W(\mu) = \begin{cases} 0 & \mu \in [0, \frac{1}{3}] \quad \big(\mu \leq \frac{1}{3} + 2 * 0\big) \\ \frac{\mu - 1/3}{2} & \mu \in [\frac{1}{3}, 1] \\ 1 & \mu \geq \frac{1}{3} + 2 = \frac{7}{3} \ \text{ (not possible)} \end{cases}$$

Conditional expected total latency for $\mu \in [\frac{1}{3}, 1]$ is

$$\begin{aligned} C(\mu) &= \left(1 - \frac{\mu - 1/3}{2}\right)\mu + \left(\frac{\mu - 1/3}{2}\right)\left(\tfrac{1}{3} + 2\frac{\mu - 1/3}{2}\right) \\ &= \mu - \frac{\mu^2 - \mu/3}{2} + \frac{\mu^2 - \mu/3}{2} = \mu \end{aligned}$$

For $\mu \in [0, \frac{1}{3}]$ it's

$$C(\mu) = (1 - 0)\mu + 0(\tfrac{1}{3} + 2 * 0) = \mu$$

So $C(\mu) = \mu$, $\forall \mu \in [0, 1]$.

Uniqueness. Fix μ and suppose the Wardrop equilibrium is not unique. Then there exists $0 \le x < x' \le 1$ such that both flows satisfy the Wardrop condition.
$0 < x' \implies$ path 2 latency is no worse than path 1 latency: $\mu \ge \frac{1}{3} + 2x'$.
$x < 1 \implies$ path 1 latency is no worse than path 2 latency: $\mu \le \frac{1}{3} + 2x$. So

$$\tfrac{1}{3} + 2x' \le \mu \le \tfrac{1}{3} + 2x \implies x' \le \frac{\mu - \frac{1}{3}}{2} \le x$$

which contradicts $x < x'$. Therefore the equilibrium is unique.

(b) **Mean-posterior identity.**

(c) **Public signal rule.**

(d) *[update]*

(e) *[update]*

(f) *[update]*

Problem 4 (Employment recommendations)

(a) *[update]*

(b) *[update]*

(c) *[update]*

(d) *[update]*